

information will be included. An independent student is assumed to be paying for their own education, and does not need to include their parents' financial information. To find more details and information about whether or not you are considered a dependent or independent student, visit studentaid.gov/apply-for-aid/fafsa/filling-out/dependency.

Once you have submitted your financial information, you will receive a detailed report of your responses and your eligibility for financial aid; this is called your **Student Aid Report (SAR)**. The SAR also tells you how much money you and/or your family should reasonably be expected to pay. This amount is called your **expected family contribution (EFC)**. If you and your family do not make much money, you will likely have a lower EFC. If you and your family make a lot of money, you will be expected to be able to pay much more, so you will have a higher EFC. It is important to remember that just because a school expects your family to be able to contribute a certain amount, it does not mean that your family actually can. You need to speak with your family and find out how much they can truly afford to contribute to your education.

Once you have completed your FAFSA, you wait until you get those sweet, sweet acceptance letters from the colleges you have applied to. When a school accepts you, they will provide you with a **financial award letter** (sometimes called a merit letter, award letter, or financial aid package). The financial award letter tells you how much it is actually going to cost you to attend the school. The award letter compares your EFC to the school's **cost of attendance (COA)**, which is the total cost of tuition, fees, books, room and board (if you live on campus), and other expenses.